

PRE-DREADNOUGHT BATTLESHIP

MIKASA

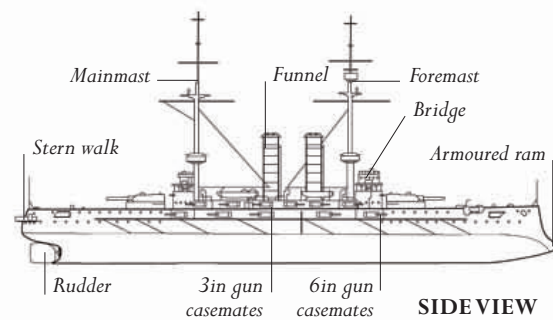
The only remaining example of a pre-dreadnought battleship, the *Mikasa* was the Japanese flagship at the Battle of Tsushima, in 1905 (pp.264–65), which saw the Imperial Russian fleet virtually annihilated.

Based on the Royal Navy's Majestic class, the *Mikasa* was the last of four similar battleships built in British yards for the Imperial Japanese Navy. Constructed by Vickers at Barrow-in-Furness, the *Mikasa* entered service on 1 March 1902.

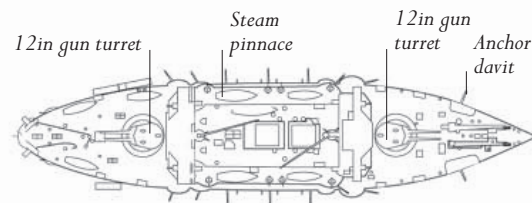
The ship's main armament consisted of four 12in guns, 40 calibres long, mounted in twin centre-line turrets fore and aft. These could be fired at a rate of three shots every two minutes. The *Mikasa*'s secondary armament included fourteen 6in quick-firing guns, lighter guns for defence against destroyers and torpedo-boats, and four submerged torpedo tubes.

The *Mikasa* was one of the first ships to have "Krupp Cemented" steel armour. In addition to forming the main deck, this armour was fitted in belts around the waterline up to 23cm (9in) thick, and

in 356mm- (14in-) thick "barbettes" around the 12in gun installations. The armour proved effective at Tsushima, when some 30 hits from Russian guns failed to put the *Mikasa* out of action. Ironically, the ship sank in harbour four months later after an accidental explosion in a magazine. Although raised in 1906 and repaired, the *Mikasa* never saw combat again and was decommissioned in 1923. It is now a museum ship at Yokosuka.



SIDE VIEW



PLAN VIEW

▲ MIKASA

About 132m (432ft) long and displacing 15,180 tons, the *Mikasa* was powered by two triple-expanding steam engines that gave a top speed of 18 knots.

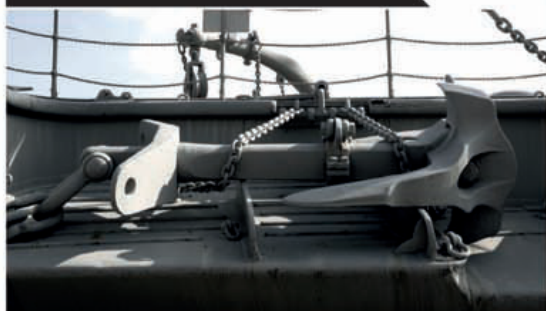
◀ BRIDGE

The pilot house (left) and chartroom (right) are topped by an open platform bearing a compass and range-finder. It was from here that, Admiral Togo Heihachiro commanded the Japanese fleet at Tsushima.

▼ 12IN GUNTURRET

The *Mikasa*'s original 12in guns could fire a 385kg (850lb) projectile 13.5km (8½ miles). They were replaced by 45-calibre pieces during the 1906 rebuild.

BRIDGE AND FORWARD



▲ FORE ANCHOR

Once raised, the anchor was returned to a platform just below upper-deck level, rather than to the hawsehole. It was brought there by a davit.



▲ COMMAND POST

Orders were given to the pilot house via a speaking tube (left) beside the compass.



▲ SEARCHLIGHT

The wing searchlights were used to locate other vessels at night and for long-distance signalling.



▲ REARVIEW OF BRIDGE

Situated in front of the foremast, the bridge gives an uninterrupted view forwards and to each side. The long "wings" of the bridge, on which two 90cm (35in) electric searchlights are mounted, extend the full width of the ship.

▲ PORTHOLE

Small glazed portholes, which could be sealed closed, were located only in unarmoured parts of the hull.